

Once you sign up, the first step to get anywhere is to import all your e-mail contacts and find out if they are already on LinkedIn. In all likelihood, at least a couple should be. This will give you enough a head start to going ahead and building your network. You may also invite the people in your address book to join and participate in the LinkedIn network. The contact list can be either from your e-mail client like Outlook or Outlook Express, or from your Web mail accounts like Gmail, Yahoo!, Hotmail or AOL.



Connect to your peers and colleagues from around the globe

LinkedIn works on the principle of three degrees of separation. It assumes that if you trust the friends and contacts who are linked directly to you, then you will also trust any of the persons who are linked to your direct friends and contacts. Based on this trust your network of access to professionals in many fields will increase with time as the number of contacts in your direct network grow. As your network grows you will be able to gain access to an ever-widening collection of people who can be a source of business opportunity or assistance.

The key to creating a solid network is to keep your profile updated and accurate in all respects. Thus, if someone is looking for a person with a specific skill set that matches yours, then you have a higher likelihood of securing that assignment due to your direct familiarity with the contact or due to common friends you both trust. Building your network and maintaining an up to date and accurate profile are the only active tasks you need to be careful about to promote your network. You can further increase your visibility by getting your colleagues, business partners, customers and service providers to provide you with recommendations on your skills and other aspects. Likewise you can provide recom-